

ENEMY LINES
An Akhilesh Yadav rally in Gorakhpur, Feb. 27

for the potential exodus of non-Yadav OBCs from the BJP's umbrella.

UMBRELLA OR RAINBOW?

The BJP, of course, plays that down, belittling the SP alliance as a non-cohesive agglomeration of caste-based parties locked in conflict with each other. The ultimate BJP project is to cement all the elements behind a universalising 'big party' logic. Anupriya Patel syncs with that sentiment. Her Apna Dal is not only drawing from Kurmi support, even other OBC/ MBC groups and Dalits come under their sway, she tells INDIA TODAY. "We have a hold among all castes. That's why we win."

Arun Rajbhar, son of O.P. Rajbhar and SBSP spokesperson, insists the opposite is true. Firstly, the Rajbhar votebank has an impact on all the seats in Purvanchal, he says. Moreover, in his opinion, the aggregation of castes is not just a numerical thing—there's a real synergy. He denies the BJP charge of disunity on the ground with the SP cadre. "We are getting more support from the SP than we expected. It is a natural alliance. In 2017, when we had an alliance with the BJP, they used to treat us differently because we are MBCs but SP leaders have given us full respect." Sanjay Chauhan, chief of Janvadi Party (Socialist), too, says: "The Samajwadi Party supported us in every way. Our alliance with them was sealed in the Lok Sabha when Akhilesh*ji* gave me a ticket from Chandauli, so we will always remain with them." He also cites the key role the Nonia Chauhans will play in over a dozen districts.

A WHOLE ARCHIPELAGO OF NON-ELITE CASTES, ESPECIALLY NON-YADAV OBCs AND NON-JATAV DALITS, DOMINATE POCKETS OF PURVANCHAL

The war of rhetoric goes all the way up to the top. Last Saturday, February 26, Akhilesh struck in the heart of enemy camp. After his massive rally and three-hour-long roadshow in Gorakhpur, he said: "The respect and love I got here is unmatchable. This shows BJP is going to lose here badly." On Monday, Yogi's riposte came: the BJP had already won, he said, and the last two phases were only going to take the tally above 300. The heavier artillery is on its way. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is likely to stay for three days on a trot in his Lok Sabha constituency, Varanasi, which votes in the seventh phase. In 2017, the BJP had won all the eight seats in Varanasi, and eight out of nine in Gorakhpur. The lone BSP MLA joined the SP earlier this year. And Akhilesh has also found a potential crack in the BJP's *savarna* base: against Yogi, he has fielded Shubhawati Shukla, widow of late BJP leader Upendra Dutt Shukla, seeking to cash in on the Thakur-vs-Brahmin narrative.

THE RATION CARD

One of the themes that has picked up of late is the free ration the state provides. Jaya Devi, a 54-year-old woman in Baghai village of Kushinagar, is ready to switch loyalties from the BSP to BJP for that. "*Jinka namak kha rahe hain, unko vote dene mein kya burai*" (what's wrong if our vote is loyal to those who give us bread)?" she says. The freebie itself produces contrary reactions on the ground. Munna Chauhan, a 32-year-old from the same village, asks, "How long can you live on free rations if there is no employment? We want jobs." His neighbour Ramesh Yadav praises the ration scheme but says he will go with "*apne log* (own people)"—that is, SP.

BJP functionaries also point to the 340-km-long Purvanchal Expressway, the Kashi Corridor and development work in the districts surrounding Varanasi to predict a landslide victory. SP leaders counter it by raising the question of jobs, inflation and stray cattle. Both sides, by their own reckoning, are splitting areas of total dominance between them—Varanasi, Mirzapur, Ballia and Chandauli for the BJP, and Mau, Azamgarh, Ambedkarnagar and Ghazipur for the SP. Prof. Kaviraj, political analyst, claims the SP's caste coalitions have made the BJP's path tougher, because the smaller castes come as add-ons over the SP's traditional Muslim-Yadav base. On the other side, Modi still plays out as an X-factor. Someone somewhere will have a casting vote in this tie-breaker too. Will it be someone who wants free ration or someone who believes power itself must be distributed? ■